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‘There’s still so much we need to know about the lives of the enslaved and of Black people in this earlier period.’

KYERA SINGLETON, executive director, Royall House and Slave Quarters



CHRISTIAN KANTOSKY FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

When Kelly Thomas came across the stone marked “Boston” in the Granary Burying Ground, she researched its origin.

AN OLD GRAVE REVEALS A LONG LOST HISTORY

Researchers piece together the life of a Black man in Colonial Boston

By Brian MacQuarrie
GLOBE STAFF

The heavy slate gravestone had long since toppled over, its coarse, uneven edges encrusted with several inches of dirt after nearly three centuries in Boston’s historic Granary Burying Ground.

When Kelly Thomas, a city employee who cares for its oldest cemeteries, read the faint script on the stone’s gray face early this year — a single name for the deceased, “Boston,” and 1728 for the year of his death — her curiosity was instantly aroused.

Weeks later, after scouring Colonial re-

cords and other research, she arrived at a startling thought: This might be the oldest grave marker for a freed Black man in the country.

“I was ecstatic,” Thomas recalled.

That inadvertent rediscovery in a tourist-filled graveyard has opened an unexpected window into the city’s past, illuminating once again how those in bondage — about 10 percent of Boston’s population at the time — helped drive the Colonial prosperity that once made Boston the largest town in British North America.

And it has brought new attention to this Black man’s struggle for the rights of the en-

slaved to marry, and his possibly pivotal role in inspiring New England’s earliest antislavery tract.

For Kyera Singleton, executive director of the Royall House and Slave Quarters, a former plantation in Medford, the grave also serves as a rare connection with the hidden Black community in Colonial Boston.

“There’s still so much we need to know about the lives of the enslaved and of Black people in this earlier period,” Singleton said. “When we can find out where they’re buried and their family histories, we’re able to build out their lives and understand the world

GRAVE, Page A10

Ballot questions remain unsettled

Lawmakers still talking on bills taking aim at tax refunds, public records

By Chris Van Buskirk
GLOBE STAFF

The halls of the State House might fall largely silent in the coming months, but negotiations will continue in private over measures that could affect a variety of issues, including several that could upend ballot questions before voters in November.

Several prominent initiative petitions have already been struck from the ballot by the state’s highest court for legal reasons. And Massachusetts lawmakers are weighing language that could blunt the effects of two others: one involving the size and frequency of refunds from surplus tax collections and a second to subject the governor’s office and Legislature to the state’s public records law.

On Beacon Hill Friday night, legislators ended their traditional stretch of formal sessions, leaving a raft of work to closed-door negotiations where House and Senate leaders will try to resolve differences between bills their members had separately passed in earlier sessions.

Legislators can strike deals on those policies at any point through early January under an internal rules change they approved last year.

Evan Horowitz, executive director of the Tufts Center for State Policy Analysis, said lawmakers

BILLS, Page A10

Academic publications confront AI

Soaring submissions prompt new guidelines

By Aidan Ryan
GLOBE STAFF

For more than 50 years, the political and cultural magazine Boston Review has given emerging and established writers a platform to go deeper than the headlines on the world’s most pressing issues: war, the rise of authoritarianism, growing inequality.

Typically, the publication’s three editors will receive 500 to 700 unsolicited submissions annually through its online portal. But in the past two years, the number of submitted drafts has exploded, tripling for the first six months of this year compared to the same period in 2023.

The new influx isn’t likely due to a revived interest in critical analysis. Editors at the Boston Review suspect a sobering reality: a flood of artificial intelligence-generated submissions.

“It’s a huge drain on our small staff,” said executive editor Matt Lord. “Practically speaking, there’s no world in which we can continue reading every single submission we get very closely and not make faster judgments in some cases.”

The people who run Boston’s prominent literary magazines, university-affiliated academic jour-

AI SUBMISSIONS, Page A7



Puddle pusher

Monday: Showers, stormy.
High: 77-82. Low: 65-70.

Tuesday: Sunny, less humid.
High: 83-88. Low: 67-72.

Sunrise: 5:39 Sunset: 8:01

Comics and Weather, **D4-5**.
Obituaries, **C9**.

Republican gubernatorial candidate Michael Minogue said he has “met the criteria” for disclosing his vast wealth, including assets like a \$31 million home in an ultra-exclusive club in southern Montana. **B1**.

The Red Sox hit four solo home runs, beating the Dodgers 8-4 and sweeping a three-game series in Los Angeles. **C1**.

Many — but not most — Massachusetts residents can expect to pay a little more for electricity starting this month. **D1**.

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ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

PADDLING FOR GLORY

Participants aboard the Bakers Island Express paddled toward shore after competing in the Great Salem Maritime Cardboard Boat Regatta on Saturday, part of Salem’s 400th anniversary celebration. **B1**.

Amid Smithsonian criticism, they’re taking a stand

Group compiles log of exhibits, supports staffers

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Fresh off a week of heavy criticism from conservatives, staffers at the Smithsonian’s National Museum of American History who clocked in for work last Monday morning encountered about a dozen people on the National Mall who wanted a word.

But they weren’t there to add to the accusations against the museum — quite the opposite. They held signs with phrases such as

“Keep the Smithsonian Independent!” and “Protect History,” while singing songs like “This Land is Your Land” and “America the Beautiful.”

The demonstration was organized by a group called Citizen Historians for the Smithsonian. Since August 2025, hundreds of volunteers with the group have taken more than 50,000 photos and videos documenting the art and artifacts on display at the Smithsonian’s 21 museums in Washington, D.C., and New York City, plus its traveling exhibits. The digital archive encapsulates everything from artworks by Banksy and Basquiat, the Wright Brothers’

first plane, photos of lynchings from the Jim Crow era, and the desk Thomas Jefferson used to pen the Declaration of Independence, to the skull of a Tyrannosaurus Rex.

Their motivation, members of the group say, is to provide a check on an administration set on an unreasonably narrow view of history. On July 24, Trump had issued an executive order dictating that signs be erected near the museum to warn visitors “about the ideological capture at the National Museum of American History,” the latest action in an escalating battle between the White House and the

SMITHSONIAN, Page A7



KRISTINE JONES

Members of the group Citizen Historians for the Smithsonian sang to support museum staff in Washington last week.